PRISMA in my own words

Week 1 | Farah Hammami | 13 November 2026

For me, PRISMA is a way to make a literature review transparent. It helps someone else understand where I found my papers, why I kept some of them, and why I removed others. It is not enough to say that I read many articles. I need to show how I went from my search results to the papers that actually support my work.

The main steps

Identification: I search the databases with recorded search terms and dates. I collect the records and remove duplicates, because the same paper can appear in several databases.

Screening: I read titles and abstracts to decide whether each paper could answer my review question. If I am unsure, I keep it for the full-text step instead of removing it too early.

Eligibility: I read the full text and apply the inclusion and exclusion criteria that I defined earlier. If a paper is excluded, I record the reason.

Inclusion: I keep the studies that meet the criteria, extract the useful information and explain what the evidence shows and what is still uncertain.

What the flow diagram shows

The diagram follows the records from identification to inclusion. It shows the number found, the duplicates removed, the records screened, the full texts assessed and the studies included. It also shows where and why records were lost. A reader can check whether the numbers make sense.

How I use it in FIBRO-RAG

My protocol is the plan for the review; the final flow diagram will describe what I actually did. I use PRISMA-P to organize the protocol and PRISMA-ScR for the final scoping review report. My pilot returned 347 exported records and 296 unique records, but that does not mean I have included 296 studies. I still need to screen them and check the full texts. I will keep the medical evidence review separate from my targeted AI literature search.

The main lesson is that a review should be traceable, not just a collection of interesting papers.